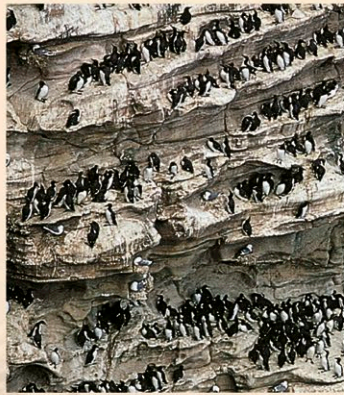


Reproduction

Most birds in this group nest on the ground, laying between one and 6 camouflaged eggs. Other species nest on cliffs, and a few, such as some terns and auks, prefer trees. Many nest colonially, in great numbers (over a million pairs in some auks), and some at extraordinary densities: incubating guillemots virtually rub shoulders with their neighbors. Numerous waders have unusual mating systems, in which either females or males have several mates. In jacanas, painted snipes, and phalaropes, the usual roles of male and female are reversed, the more colorful female initiating display, the male alone incubating the eggs and tending the young.



CLIFFSIDE COLONY

Auks often nest in extremely dense colonies. Murres (left) crowd together on cliff ledges at up to 20 pairs per square yard, their bodies virtually defining the extent of their territory. These birds lay a single egg, each with its own pattern—a way of detecting it among the many similar-looking nest sites.

Flight

The auks, with their short, pointed wings, can fly rapidly in air, but only for limited distances. They use their wings to propel themselves underwater as they swim. The waders have long, pointed wings to help them fly fast and efficiently, but although they are adept at rapid changes of pace and direction, they cannot soar. This skill can be seen in the gulls and their relatives, which spend hours on end on the wing, often traveling extremely long distances over water. Every year, the Arctic tern, which breeds north of the Arctic Circle and winters in Antarctica, travels a distance of about 10,000 miles (16,000 km) each way.



LONG-DISTANCE MIGRANTS

The Arctic tern spends much of its life in flight, feeding on the wing by catching insects in midair and flying low over water to take fishes. It breeds and migrates in large colonies. All terns perform spectacular aerial courtship displays.

CARRYING PREY

The Atlantic puffin has an extremely large, colorful bill. As with all puffins, the upper bill and tongue are ridged with spikes that enable the bird to hold a remarkable number of fishes at a time—up to 62 has been recorded.



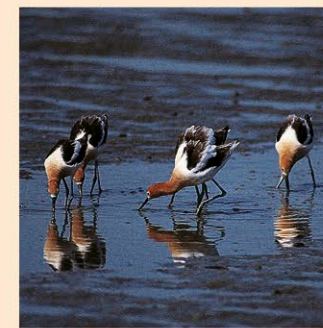
Feeding

Apart from seedsnipes, which eat plant matter, all members of this group feed on other animals. The waders probe for invertebrates on beaches, estuarine mudflats, and leaf litter. Gulls are opportunists, picking up fish, eggs, small birds, and mammals where they can, even scavenging at garbage dumps. Gulls and skuas sometimes feed by piracy, intimidating smaller birds into giving up their food. Terns plunge-dive for fish, while skimmers fly low over the water, the lower bill just touching the surface and snapping shut when prey is touched. Auks pursue their prey underwater.



WALKING ON WATER

The jacanas (here, a comb-crested jacana) walk on floating vegetation, their long toes distributing their weight and preventing them from sinking. They eat insects and seeds that they find under the leaves.



FEEDING WADERS

These American avocets are catching their prey by swishing their bill from side to side through water or very soft mud, a technique known as scything. As the bill moves, it comes into contact with edible particles in suspension.



5

HOSTILE RIVALS

Suddenly, 2 more birds appear, harassing the gull by squawking and flapping their wings.



6

CHANGING COURSE

Turning on its side, the gull heads off in a different direction to escape the pursuers.



7

MIDAIR SNATCH

One of the chasing birds has caught up with the gull and is pulling the fish out of its bill.



8

ESCAPE

Having successfully grabbed the fish, the "pirate" gull flees, pursued by the other 2 birds.